Community Futures Grants 2026: Guidance for Applicants

Round opens 1 September 2025. Closing date: 16:00 on Friday 14 November 2025.

1. About the Foundation and this programme

The Ashgrove Foundation is an independent grant-making charity supporting communities in Wrenford, Ashdale and the wider Wrenmoor district. Community Futures is our main open grants programme. It funds projects that help people and communities build secure, independent futures. In the 2026 round we expect to make around 14 grants from a budget of £620,000.

2. What we fund

We fund projects that deliver one or more of these themes. Projects may meet more than one theme. We do not prefer one theme over another; we fund the strongest applications.

- **Theme A: Skills and independence.** Practical skills, training and routes into education, work and independent living for young people aged 16 to 25 facing disadvantage, including young people leaving care.
- **Theme B: Food security and waste.** Community action that improves access to good, affordable food and reduces the amount of good food that is wasted.
- **Theme C: Stronger communities.** Volunteering and activities that bring people together and reduce isolation.

We fund new projects and the continuation or expansion of existing work that has shown results. We can fund salaries, sessional staff, running costs, equipment, vehicle lease and hire, and evaluation.

3. Who can apply

- Registered charities, charitable incorporated organisations, and community interest companies with an asset lock, based in and working in Wrenford, Ashdale or the Wrenmoor district.
- Organisations with an annual income between £50,000 and £500,000 in their most recent annual accounts.
- Organisations with at least one year of published accounts and at least three unrelated trustees or directors.
- Organisations working with children, young people or adults at risk must have a safeguarding policy reviewed in the last 12 months.
- You may submit only one application per round, for a single project. Organisations that received an Ashgrove grant in the last 12 months cannot apply.

4. How much you can apply for, and the budget rules

You can apply for between £10,000 and £60,000 in total, for a project lasting up to two years (24 months). Your budget must follow these rules. Applications that break a budget rule will not be assessed.

Rule	Requirement
B1. Total request	Between £10,000 and £60,000, for up to 24 months.
B2. Annual limit	No more than £35,000 may be requested for any single year (12-month period) of the grant.
B3. Overheads	Overheads must not exceed 15% of the total amount requested. Overheads (also called core or indirect costs) are any share of management, premises, finance, governance, IT or administration costs, however they are labelled.
B4. Capital and vehicles	Equipment and other capital items: no more than £5,000 in total. We do not fund the purchase of vehicles; vehicle lease, hire and running costs are eligible.
B5. Staff costs	Show each post, its FTE and its annual cost including employer's on-costs. Year 2 may include pay inflation of up to 3%.
B6. Ineligible lines	No contingency lines, no costs incurred before the grant starts, and no value for volunteer time (you may show volunteer time separately as an in-kind contribution).
B7. Presentation	Whole pounds, with columns for Year 1, Year 2 and Total. The budget total must match the amount requested in your project summary.

5. What we do not fund

- Purchase of vehicles, buildings or land, or building works costing more than £5,000.
- Activities that replace statutory funding or that a public body has a legal duty to provide.
- Retrospective costs, deficits, loan repayments or contributions to reserves.
- General appeals, sponsorship, or grants to individuals.
- Religious or party-political activity (faith-based organisations delivering open community services are welcome to apply).
- Work outside Wrenford, Ashdale and the Wrenmoor district.

6. Your application: required sections and word limits

Complete every section in the online form. Text beyond the word limit will not be read.

Section	What to cover	Word limit
1. Project summary	What you will do, for whom, the amount requested and the main outcome.	150
2. The need	The problem, who is affected locally and the evidence that shows it.	400
3. The project	Activities, timetable, staffing, partners and how people will take part.	500
4. Outcomes	The changes you expect, targets for each year and how you will measure them.	350
5. Budget	A justification of each budget line, plus the budget table (not counted).	300
6. Sustainability	What will happen when the grant ends and how the work will be funded.	250
Total		**1,950**

7. How we assess applications

Each eligible application is scored from 1 (weak) to 5 (excellent) against each criterion. Scores are weighted as below. Applications that score less than 3 for Need and evidence will not be shortlisted.

Criterion	Weighting	What we look for
Need and evidence	25%	Clear local need, backed by your own data and other sources.
Project design and deliverability	25%	Realistic plan, the right people and track record.
Outcomes and measurement	20%	Specific, measurable outcomes and a credible way to track them.
Value for money and budget	15%	Costs are justified, accurate and follow the budget rules.
Sustainability	15%	A believable plan for the work after the grant ends.
Total	**100%**	

8. What to send with your application

- Your most recent annual report and accounts.
- Your safeguarding policy (or a summary) and the date it was last reviewed.
- The budget table described in section 4.
- Up to two letters of support from partners (optional).

9. Timetable

Stage	Date
Round opens	Monday 1 September 2025
Last date for advice calls	Friday 31 October 2025
Closing date (late applications are not accepted)	16:00 on Friday 14 November 2025
Shortlisted applicants told	By Friday 19 December 2025
Assessment visits	January 2026
Decisions	By Friday 27 February 2026
Grants start	Between 1 April and 30 June 2026

10. Reporting and contact

Grant holders send a short progress report after 12 months and a final report within three months of the end of the grant, showing delivery against the outcomes and budget in the application. If you would like to talk about your idea before applying, call the grants team on 01632 960772 before 31 October 2025.